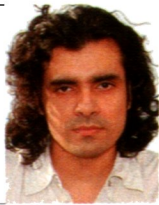




C O L U M N

Imtiaz AliA filmmaker, he
directed *Jab We Met*

No One Type

Individuals in their own right, today's youth deliberately defy all attempts at classification. In a world that celebrates diversity, they are proud to represent only themselves.

There is nothing called the youth of today. In *Jab We Met*, a film I made last year, Geet (Kareena Kapoor) talks to Aditya (Shahid Kapur) about something she knows and likes—herself: “*Main apni favourite hoon* (I am my favourite).” She does not claim to know about others. If a research executive came up to her with a form, she will not be able to help him sell his brand better to the largest market in the country, the youth.

All young people are like Geet. They represent only themselves.

A few years back, I had organised two pre-release shows of my first film, *Socha Na Tha*, in Bandra. Since the movie was of interest to the youth, a lot of college students turned up. They surprised us. They liked the second half better than the first. How was that possible? The first half was all fun and humour and young. The second half was more emotional and mature. The older generation loved the fizzy first half. Perhaps each segment loved seeing what they miss in their present lives. Or perhaps not all information can be classified.

Until over a decade ago, there was only Doordarshan and a half-hour news bulletin. So earlier we sometimes missed the news that two people died in police custody in some city. Now we know that a man in Bilaspur has a mole on his back. Earlier we all had the same information. Now no one can take in all the information available. So you choose what you like. Not every child has to grow up watching cricket. Some children grow up watching Formula One, or NBA or WWF. Or they might not be interested in sports, but in music. Today's young people are individuals with different tastes and information. All their mothers watch *saas-bahu* soaps but there



HEVANT CHAWLA

**30% say
their closest friend is
their spouse/girlfriend/
boyfriend**

is no one thing that all of them watch.

I was shooting a tourism film in Hong Kong. The crew was an interesting mix of people—an English producer, a Spanish cameraman, a French editor, an Indian director and a Chinese crew. We realised that there was more in common among us than there was between me and my neighbour in Mumbai. We were similar because we were the movie-maker ‘type’—from across the globe, sure, but that does not matter.

There are many ‘types’—the

sporty type, the library type, the rich-bitch type, the Pedder Road type, the Shahdara type. But only others are a part of these groups. In their own eyes, the young people are special. They defy classification, deliberately. Aditya puts Geet in the category of hopeless romantics and foolish optimists, but she accepts that. She does not take herself very seriously. And that is endearing because most young Indians take themselves very seriously.

There is one thing that youth do and the elders don't—they keep their traditions in their back pocket and their heads held high. Today's youth know they are good enough to sit at any dinner table. They are not embarrassed about the colour of their skin or their mother's accent. They know they are equals. But it does not unify them as a group, just differentiates them from the older generation. ■